

## INTRODUCTION

COMPARATIVELY little is known of the life of Roger Bacon. Even the exact year and place of his birth are in doubt. From a statement made by Bacon in the *Opus Tertium* we infer that he was born between 1210 and 1215. From the same source we learn that his family was one of considerable wealth, but had been reduced to utter poverty by its adherence to Henry in his dispute with his barons. He received his collegiate training at Oxford and, as he states in the *Opus Tertium*, devoted more than twenty years to the study of languages and science. "I sought," he writes, "the friendship of all wise men among the Latins; and I caused young men to be trained in languages, in geometrical figures, in numbers, in the construction of tables, in the use of instruments, and in many other necessary things. . . . During this time I spent more than two thousand pounds in those things and in the purchase of books and instruments."

About 1240 Bacon left Oxford and went to the University of Paris, where he received the degree of doctor of theology. It was during his sojourn in Paris that he entered the Franciscan Order about 1247. He subsequently returned to England, but incurring the suspicion of his superiors in the Franciscan Order he was exiled to Paris and placed under restraint in the Paris house.

Guy Fulcodi, who practiced law in Paris for a number of years with great distinction and also served as private secretary to Louis IX, entered the Church after the death of his wife and was elevated to the Papacy in 1265 as Clement IV. While in Paris he had every opportunity to hear of Bacon and his work, and was evidently so favorably impressed that after his elevation to the Papacy he wrote a letter in 1266 to Bacon directing him to transmit copies of all his writings without delay.

As a matter of fact up to this time Bacon had written but little with the exception of a formal treatise *De Multiplicatione Specierum*. Bacon began work at once and composed rapidly the *Opus Majus*, *Opus Minus*, and *Opus Tertium* and dispatched them together with a copy of the *De Multiplicatione Specierum* to the Pope by the hand of a poor lad named John,